

2c. Content of unit group 3: Thematic study and historical interpretations (Units Y301 to Y321)

Introduction to unit group 3

There are two elements to the thematic study and historical interpretations unit group:

- the thematic essay which will require learners to consider developments over at least 100 years
- the in-depth interpretation element where learners will comprehend, analyse and evaluate the ways in which the past has been interpreted by historians, by using their knowledge of specific individuals, events or developments that are prominent within the theme. Learners will be required to show an understanding of the wider historical debate connected to the issues. Three such depth studies are specified for each option.

This unit group seeks to develop an understanding of connections and interpretations between different elements of the subject and for learners to draw together knowledge, understanding and skills of diverse issues centred upon a common theme.

The topics covered by the units in this group are based on themes covering an extended period of at least 100 years with a focus on continuity, development, change and evaluation of interpretations appropriate to the topic. The emphasis is on developing and interpreting a broad overview of the period studied, whilst also considering the validity of historical interpretations on specific topics within the theme being studied, therefore combining breadth and depth. The themes identified within each topic in the unit are not to be studied in isolation to each other. They are not self-contained and learners need to examine the inter-relationships within the theme being studied.

The thematic essays will focus on making links and comparisons between different aspects of the topics studied and of testing hypotheses before reaching a judgement.

The depth studies will require learners to evaluate historians' interpretations of the named events (etc). This will provide learners with the opportunity to assess and evaluate the arguments using their analytical skills and knowledge of the wider historical debates. They will have the opportunity to show they can discriminate between different interpretations to reach a supported judgement on the issue on which they are being examined.

There will always be **one** interpretation style question set for examination on **one** of the three depth studies. The interpretations selected will always be deliberate constructs by historians, produced much later than the historical event. They represent progression from interpretations as examined at AS level in that they will require analysis of a greater depth and range of evidence. Therefore, the interpretations set will always be longer extracts (substantial paragraphs). The interpretations set for examination will provide candidates with the opportunity to analyse and evaluate by locating them in the wider historical debate. Interpretations will be fully attributed and will only be edited for accessibility.

Further advice and guidance on this unit group is available from the OCR website. The following pages detail the content options available.